VOLUME-2

EPISODE-1

REBUILD ASHTON

POLICE
POLICE
POLICE
POLICE
Seriously?
KRAAAANG!
You should worry about yourself, old man.
THOOM!
Here we go.
KRA-BOOM!
You're tougher than you look.
And you're louder than necessary.

Looking at the scenery?

Making sure you don't destroy it.

Oh, come on.

Got you.

You know, I really hate this position.

SHING!

Perfect timing, I guess.

My turn.

KRA-THOOOM!

See? I can be careful.

Work on the definition.

Not so fast!

Ahh shit!

Is it a belt or chain?

Just a rope i guess.

And stop moving man!

Careful! There's a beautiful café on the right side!

CAFÉ BELLA

I noticed.

Good! I'd hate to explain property damage to the owner.

Focus on the mutant, Laks.

I'm multitasking!

KRA-BOOM!

Alpha. The Beast is approaching the park.

I'll take care of that.

Please do. I'd rather not rebuild another neighbourhood.

Neither would I.

ASHTON CENTRAL PARK

KRA-THOOM!

Stay down.

Finally.

CRACK!

Guardians,
let's finish them.

KRAK!

Enough.

That one should stay down.

Let's hope so.

THOOM!

Teamwork makes the dream work.

Perfect.

One down.

Three to go.

Or perhaps fewer.

You're not taking me in!

Do you think so.

You have made your point.

I'M NOT DONE!

Then you'll have plenty of time to think about it.

CAFÉ BELLA

CAFE BELLA

ASHTON CENTRAL PARK

CAFÉ BELLA

LOCAL INFRASTRUCTURE DAMAGE: 13%

Thirteen percent. That's considerably lower than our previous battles.

We're getting better.

Never thought I'd spend this much time cleaning up after a fight.

Protecting people doesn't end when the enemy falls.

Finish before sontber. ane

This might be bun cleanest victory yet.

Thirteen percent damage. Nobody seriously hurt. Four mutants detained.

Yeah. I'd call that progress.

It is progress. But we still have a long way to go. We need to keep reducing the damage. And, more importantly, prevent these battles from happening ithe first place.

Assuming the people starting them give us a chance.

That's exactly why we need to be better prepared.

Alpha?

We're getting better day by day. After what happened a month ago, look at us now.

We'll rebuild what was damaged. We'll earn back people's trust. Eventually, we'll clear the doubts they have about us.

When I twisted his head that day...

The only thought inside my mind was to do something. Anything. Just end it.

I wasn't thinking about what came after. I wasn't thinking about what it would make me.

I just wanted it to stop.

What if that thought comes back, Kat?

What if I reach that point again and I can't stop myself?

I don't know what I'll do next time.

And that scares me more than anything we've fought.

We've already taken steps to stop this from happening again.

We closed the borders with Dark City three weeks ago. Every possible transaction between the two cities has been stopped.

We cut off their routes into Ashton. We tightened security. We made it harder for Chaos to operate here.

DARK CITY BORDER CLOSED

But criminals are still getting into our city.

ALL TRADE SUSPENDED

ASHTON

If the borders are closed, and their transactions are stopped, how are these people still getting through?

Maybe we're looking in the wrong direction.

Maybe there's still something inside our own organization that we haven't found.

CHAOS SYNDICATE
CONFERENCE HALL
DARK CITY

CRASH!

Fuck! Fuck! Everything—every fucking thing is ending badly!

CRAAASH!

Every fucking experiment is a failure!

Every single one!

FAILED

FAILED

FAILED

Stop it, Proto.

Master?

BOSS

You trusted me. But my results keep failing. Again and again.

Nothing has failed, Proto.

Everything so far has been useful to us.

Your biggest experiment didn't fail.

It created our opportunity.

These small failures?

Pebbles on the road to that opportunity.

We're getting closer to victory, Proto.

Don't make yourself vulnerable because a few things didn't go your way.

Underssood, Master.

One more thing.

Leave the mutants who have failed us repeetedly.

We have no use for dead weight.

CHAOS SYNDICATE
CONFERENCE HALL
DARK CITY
FAILED
Rough night?
Am I interrupting something?
No.
Come in.
Only those who are actually useful remain here.
Then I suppose I'll be staying.
There's something I've been wondering.
Why are you so desperate for that Key? What exactly is it?
That Key belongs to Megasto.
Megasto?
He may come here soon.
I need to return the key.
Build a team that's balanced. Coordinated.
Like the Guardians.
GUARDIANS SYNDICATE
WHITE WITCH
ALPHA VOID
ATOM GIRL
RAMPAGE
They work together. Each one covers what the others lack.
We need the same advantage.
Next time, failure belongs to them.
I can do that.
I'll find the right pieces.
Choose carefully.
I won't give you another chance to choose badly.
I knew man.
ALPHA VOID
ALPHA VOID
Master?
All of it?
Clean this up.
Especially the parts you thought were useless.
Guardians...
You've had your victories.

BEEP...
BEEP...
BEEP...
98
110
20
She'll be discharged next week.
Oh. That's good to hear.
Are you family?
What? No, no. I mean, I just came here to see her.
Not in a weird way. I'm not related to her. I just wanted to check on her.
Interesting.
A big hero comes all the way here to visit a little girl he doesn't even know.
When you say it like that, it sounds a little strange.
Doesn't it?
During the battle in the city one month ago, her home was completely destroyed.
We cleared the debris afterwards. That's when we found her.
I remember seeing her being carried out.
She was so small beneath all that rubble.
For a moment, I thought we'd arrived too late.
I kept wondering whether she would make it.
She was admitted here immediately.
She remained in a coma for two weeks.
Her injuries were severe. There were times when we couldn't be certain how much she would recover.
But she's been responding well to treatment.
She'll undergo surgery tomorrow.
If everything goes as expected, she'll recover well enough to leave the hospital next week.
Really?
Really.
That's... that's wonderful.
Thank you, Doctor.
She reminds me of myself when I was a kid.
I guess that's why I wanted to see her get better so badly.
I wanted to know she'd get the chance to grow up.
To have a normal life.
Seeing her get back on her feet would mean a lot to me.
You know something?
People see heroes saving buildings, stopping criminals, fighting monsters.
But they don't always see what happens afterwards.
Sometimes, the hardest part begins when the fighting stops.

Do you know what the softest part of the human body is?

The softest part?

Maybe our hair or something?

You're a Shape Shifter, and you don't know anything about the human body?

First of all, that's a terrible question.

Second, I can change my body. That doesn't mean I studied biology.

You're the doctor. You're supposed to know these things.

Fair enough.

It's the heart.

Not necessarily the softest in a medical sense. But the heart...

That's where people carry so much of what keeps them going.

Fear. Hope. The will to survive.

And sometimes, that's the difference between someone giving up and someone fighting their way back.

That little girl has one of the strongest hearts I've ever seen.

With the injuries she suffered, many people would have struggled to survive.

But she kept fighting.

Even when she couldn't open her eyes, her body kept fighting for her.

BEEP... BEEP... BEEP...

92
118
20

That's what has brought her this far.

And if she keeps recovering like this, you'll see her walking out of here very soon.

I hope so.

I'd really like to see that.

Then you'll have to come back and check on her.

You're making me a regular visitor now?

Someone has to make sure you don't mistake another patient's hair for a medical condition.

By the way, I never got your name, Doctor.

Ah, sorry. I never introduced myself.

I'm Kroos Bunker.

Kroos...?

Bunker. Kroos Bunker.

Right. Got it.

Thanks for taking care of her.

GRIP.

That's my job. But it's nice to know someone out there cares about what happens after we do ours.

I'll come back next week, then.

She'll probably be waiting to show you how much better she feels.

Then I'd better bring a gift.

Bring something other than a biology textbook.

No promises!

92
118
20

One month after the unleash,
some wounds were still being repaired.

Hold it there!

It's there.

Already here?

Someone had to be.

Move aside.
You're making this look harder than it is.

Am I?

Now that's what I call construction!

We should've asked for superhoro assistance a month ago!

This easy, the work?

Yeah! I could build my own building with these powers.

Though I'd have to focus a little more.

Architect.

Hey!
At least my buildings wouldn't take six months!

Three, then.

So...
Do you always spend your free time doing this?

When there's work.

That's not the question.

Then?

You know, we've been working together for a while.

Yes.

And I barely know anything about you.

Efficient arrangement.

You're impossible.

Often.

You're impossible.

What were you doing before the Guardians?

Working.

Doing what?

Different things.

Like what?

Things that paid.

What about your family?

Did you grow up here in Ashton?

Hey...

Sorry. If you don't want to share it, leave it.

I didn't mean to make you uncomfortable.

I lost my parents when I was twenty-four.

During the human-mutant civil fight.

That left me and my baby sister alone.

We grew up in this city.

I did whatever jobs I could find.

Someone had to take care of her.

I killed almost everyone they pointed me towards.

ALLEY CORP.

Even people who didn't deserve it.

TARGET

And one day changed everything.

I'm sorry.

You were just trying to survive. And take care of your sister.

What happened next?

Did what was necessary.

Hope and Trust

Not now.

Hope and Trust

You can't just stand there and expect everything to be normal.

Amy.

Don't.

Okay.

Hope and Trust

That's it?

You told me not to.

And you're just going to listen?

I can do that.

You always had something to say.

Some explanation. Some ridiculous answer that somehow made sense when you said it.

Now you don't have anything?

I have a lot to say.

I just don't know what you deserve to hear first.

How about the truth?

You're right.

I should've given you that from the beginning.

I could tell you why I kept it secret.

I could tell you I was trying to protect you.

But that wouldn't change what I did.

You trusted me.

And. I let you believe you knew everything about me when you didn't.

I'm sorry, Amy.

Do you know what the worst part was?

It wasn't finding out who you were.

It was wondering whether any of the time we spent together was real.

Every conversation. Every time you showed up. Every time I told you something I hadn't told anyone else.

I kept asking myself whether you were talking to me as yourself... or because you thought you owed me something.

Every moment was real.

When I was with you, I wasn't thinking about being Alpha.

I was just the guy who wanted to talk to you.

The guy who liked hearing you talk about your work, even when I didn't understand half the things you were saying.

The guy who looked forward to seeing you.

That part was never a lie.

You didn't understand half the things I was saying?

Probably less than half.

Wow.

I was trying to be honest.

I was angry with you.

I know.

No, I was really angry.

I gathered that.

Don't make jokes.

Sorry.

I wasn't angry because you were a superhero.

I was angry because you decided I couldn't handle the truth.

You're right.

I spent so long trying to keep my life separate.

I thought if people knew who I was, everyone around me would become a target.

Then I started believing that keeping everyone safe meant deciding what they were allowed to know.

I never stopped to ask whether that was fair to them.

I thought I was protecting people.

Maybe I was also protecting myself.

You know, for someone who can hear things from miles away, you can be unbelivvably bad at listening.

That's fair.

And you don't get to make every decision for everyone just because you can save them.

I'm beginning to understand that.

Good. Because I wasn't planning on letting you live that one down.

I wasn't exactly honest with you either.

What do you mean?

I kept pretending I was fine with everything.

When I was working at Daily Coverage, I hated watching other reporters get opportunities I couldn't even dream of.

I wanted to work for AshtonDaily so badly that sometimes I felt like I was falling behind everyone else.

And I kept acting like none of that bothered me.

Why didn't you tell me?

That makes sense.

Also, I didn't want the most powerful man in Ashton trying to solve my career problems.

Because I wanted to prove I could make it on my own.

I wouldn't have done that

You would absolutely have done that.

...I might have.

I wanted you to see me as someone who could do something important.

Not just someone who needed saving.

I never thought you needed saving.

You didn't?

I thought you were stubborn enough to walk into a dangerous situation just to get a story.

That is not a compliment.

It wasn't meant to be.

Can I ask you something?

Anything.

That day... when you fought your look-alike. After everything was over, what happened to you?

I keep remembering the moment I killed him.

I knew what I was doing.

And I did it anyway.

For a moment, I didn't care about anything except making it stop.

That frightened me.

Everyone keeps telling me I saved people that day.

Maybe I did.

But I still have to live with what I did to save them.

I don't know what happens if I reach that point again.

And I don't want to pretend I have the answer so I flew away to the sky to think.

I'm sorry, Amy. You deserved the truth, and I should've trusted you with it.

I'm not asking you to forget what happened. I'll earn your trust back.

You know, you're still an idiot.

That's fair.

A powerful idiot.

At least you remember that part.

So, what happens now?

Maybe we start by being honest with each other.

That would be a nice change.

Agreed.

No more deciding what I can handle. If something's wrong, tell me.

I will.

And I'll stop pretending I'm fine when I'm not.

And if something happens again?

I'll tell you what I can.

Not because I think you need protecting from the truth.

Because you deserve to know where we stand.

And I'll tell you when I'm angry instead of pretending I'm not.

That might be the scarier part.

Ah Ahn Is it?

Not more scarier than darkcity it's okay.

Friends?

Friends.

But don't make me regret it, Mr.Rogers.

I'll try my best, Ms. Adams.

Well, Rogers. Still terrible at conversations.

And you're still impossible to please.

Good. Some things shouldn't change.

GUARDIANS SYNDICATE
HEADQUARTERS
UNDERGROUND
DETENTION CENTER
NIGHT

B1
B2
B3
B4
B5

A private detention center. For those the Syndicate can no longer trust.

Queen. We weren't informed you'd be visiting today.

I don't need an appointment.

Of course. Which detaiene would you like to see?

I need to visit him.

Open the inner door.

CLUNK.

How is your stay here, Taylor?

Katherine?
Yeah, not so bad.

I still can't believe that you're here.

Well, here I am.

Why exactly are you here, Katherine?

Why am I here? You really don't know?

I'm one of the founders of this organization. And yet, somehow, I never knew that you were the black spot in our organization all along.

If you're here for this, leave me alone.

I don't have anything to talk about with you.

Your sister really trusted you.

Even when she was unstable, she believed in you. She believed you'd follow her path.

You don't know anything, Katherine!

So don't blabber about things you don't understand. Leave!

Then enlighten me.

Tell me what I need to know.

Even if I told you, you wouldn't understand.
I've been doing this for decades.
Decades, Katherine.
And only Alpha managed to find out.
Not the council. Not the people running this organization.
Not even you.
Yes! I don't know about you!
Because I trusted you!
I thought you would do good, just as your sister did. I thought you understoed what this organization was supposed to stand for.
But you failed.
What kind of man sells his own city and its people for some compromise bullshit?
STOP, KATHERINE!
BANG!
You're one of the founders of this fucking organization!
But you don't really know what they've been doing all this time!
What?
I can't...
I can't say any more.
Taylor.
Finish what you were trying to say, Taylor.
Why?
I can't, Katherine.
...
SNAP.
SECURITY MONITORING ROOM
GUARDIANS SYNDICATE HQ
What's happening? Why can't I hear anything? What happened to the audio?
Camera's still transmitting. The video feed is fine.
Then why is the audio dead?

I muted the recording.
No one can hear us now.
Now tell me, Taylor.
Without hiding behind excuses. Without worrying about who's listening.
Tell me what you know.
You wouldn't believe what the Syndicate actually is.
Then tell me.
Listen carefully, Katherine.
They weren't built to protect or serve the people.
That's what they want everyone to believe.
But that's not what this organization was built for.
It was built to control people.
The economy. The country. Everything that keeps this world moving.
They decide what people should do, what they should say...
Even what they should think.
What are you talking about?
This organization has protected millions of people. We've fought threats that ordinary people couldn't even imagine.
You're telling me all of that was a lie?
I'm telling you that you've only seen what they wanted you to see.
Do you think you were the one who came up with the Guardians?
The team. The symbol. The whole idea of the Guardians protecting Ashton.
You really think it all started with you?
Then?
No, Katherine.
They created the team to hide what was happening inside the organization.
The Guardians gave people someone to believe in.
And while everyone looked at you, they never thought to look behind you.
You were just a pawn in their game, Katherine.
And I wasn't the bad guy you people made me out to be.
I was doing something good. Just in unconventional ways.
You can call it betrayal. You can call it corruption. You can lock me in here and tell yourselves you've solved the problem.
But none of that changes what I've been trying to do.
The Syndicate is more than you can imagine.
Then explain it to me!
What have they done? What are they hiding? Who is actually running this organization?
Katherine, the truth is—

CLANK!
Director, she's in the final cell.
I can see that.
Taylor. Finish what you were saying.
You were about to tell me the truth. Don't stop now.
0721
Go now, Katherine.
See with your own eyes what's happening.
What am I supposed to see?
Everything is already before your eyes.
You just need to change the way you look at it.
SEARCH.
Ma'am? Did Taylor say anything to you?
Yes, actually.
He wanted a bigger room. Something a little more comfortable.
Apparently, the bed isn't tbo his liking.
Make a note of it.
And, Director?
Yes, ma'am?
Make sure he gets it.
I'd hate for him to complain again.
...
Something about this doesn't sit right.
TAYLOR (MEMORY)
They weren't built to protect or serve the people.
They decide what people should do, what they should say...
Even what they should think.
TAYLOR (MEMORY)
Everything is already before your eyes.
You just need to change the way look at it.
TAYLOR (MEMORY)
SEARCH.
GUARDIANS SYNDICATE HEADQUARTERS MAIN HALL
PEOPLE SAFER TOMORROW BRIGHTER
HOPE PROTECTION FREEDOM TOGETHER
TAYLOR (MEMORY)
You were just a pawn in their game, Katherine.
TAYLOR (MEMORY)
Everything is already before your eyes.
TAYLOR (MEMORY)
SEARCH.
TO BE CONTINUED